Pongal and the Festivals of Tamil Nadu

Introduction to Pongal

Pongal is the most important harvest festival of Tamil Nadu, celebrated by Tamil people all over the world in mid-January, at the start of the Tamil month of Thai. It marks the end of the harvest season and the beginning of the sun's northward journey, called Uttarayanam. The word "Pongal" means "to boil over" or "overflowing" in Tamil, and it refers to the dish prepared on the day of the festival, a sweet rice dish cooked with new rice, milk and jaggery, which is allowed to boil over the pot as a sign of abundance and prosperity. The festival is a way for farmers to thank the Sun God, Surya, nature, the rain and their cattle for a good harvest. It is also celebrated as Makar Sankranti in other parts of India, as Lohri in Punjab, as Bihu in Assam and as Uttarayan in Gujarat. Tamil Nadu declares several days of holiday, and January is also celebrated as Tamil Heritage Month.

Over How Many Days Is Pongal Celebrated?

Pongal is celebrated over four days, around 13 to 17 January each year, usually from 14 January. The four days are Bhogi Pongal, Thai Pongal, Mattu Pongal and Kaanum Pongal.

Bhogi, the first day, is dedicated to Lord Indra, the god of rain. On this day, people clean their homes, throw away old and unwanted things and burn them in a bonfire made of wood and cow dung cakes, symbolising the end of the old and the start of the new. Houses are decorated with mango leaves and kolams, and children and young people play the drum called bhogi kottu.

Thai Pongal, the second and main day, falls on the first day of the Tamil month of Thai. A new clay pot, decorated with turmeric plants and sugarcane, is filled with fresh rice, milk and jaggery, and cooked outdoors in the courtyard in the morning in the direction of the rising sun. When the milk boils over, the family shouts "Pongalo Pongal!" and offers the food to the Sun God. The dish is made along with ven pongal, a savoury version, and many other dishes.

Mattu Pongal, the third day, honours cattle, which are vital for farmers. Cows and bulls are washed, painted with colours, decorated with garlands and bells, and fed with pongal, sugarcane and bananas. Jallikattu and bull races are held on this day.

Kaanum Pongal, the fourth day, is a day for visiting relatives and friends, going for picnics, and meeting family. "Kaanum" means "to see". Sisters pray for the welfare of their brothers, and people go to beaches, such as the Marina in Chennai, and rivers.

What Is Jallikattu?

Jallikattu is a traditional bull-taming sport held in Tamil Nadu during the Mattu Pongal festival in January, particularly in the districts of Madurai, Dindigul, Theni, Sivaganga and Pudukkottai. Famous venues are Alanganallur, Palamedu and Avaniyapuram near Madurai. In the event, a bull from a native breed such as the Kangayam, Pulikulam or Umblachery is released from an enclosure into a crowd of young men, who try to grab the hump of the bull and hold on to it to retrieve the prizes tied to its horns, or to stay with it for a certain distance, without using weapons. The name comes from "salli kasu" (coins) and "kattu" (tied), referring to the bag of coins tied to the horns. Bulls are raised carefully by villagers as members of the family. The sport is believed to be more than 2,000 years old, since bull-taming scenes are thought to appear on Indus seals and old rock paintings, and Sangam poetry mentions it as "eru thazhuvuthal".

Jallikattu is controversial. Animal rights groups such as PETA and the Animal Welfare Board of India say that it harms the animals and causes injuries and deaths of participants and spectators. In 2014, the Supreme Court banned it. In January 2017, there were huge protests across Tamil Nadu, notably at the Marina Beach in Chennai, led by young people who said that it was part of Tamil culture and the way to protect native bull breeds. The Tamil Nadu government passed an amendment law in 2017, with rules for regulating it, and in May 2023 the Supreme Court upheld the law.

What Is Kolam?

Kolam is a traditional art form in which patterns are drawn on the ground at the entrance of homes using rice flour, chalk powder or white stone powder. Women usually draw the kolam every morning after sprinkling water and cow dung mix or water on the ground, before sunrise. It is known as rangoli in North India. The designs may be pulli kolam, made with dots (pulli) joined by lines, or free-hand kolam, and they can be geometric and symmetrical, with coloured powders on festival days. Kolam is believed to welcome Goddess Lakshmi and bring prosperity, to keep away evil, and to be a way of feeding ants, birds and other small creatures, since rice flour is used. It is also a form of mathematical and artistic training, and researchers have studied its patterns in mathematics and computer science. During Pongal, large and colourful kolams are drawn with sugarcane, pots and the Sun, and there are competitions.

Other Festivals of Tamil Nadu

Tamil Puthandu, the Tamil New Year, is celebrated on 14 April. Aadi Perukku in July and August celebrates the rising of the rivers. Karthigai Deepam in November and December is the festival of lights, with the huge beacon lit at the Arunachaleswarar Temple in Tiruvannamalai. Deepavali, Navaratri, with the arrangement of dolls called Golu, Vinayaka Chaturthi, Thaipusam, Panguni Uthiram and Maha Shivaratri are also widely celebrated. The Chithirai Thiruvizha in Madurai, in April and May, celebrates the celestial wedding of Goddess Meenakshi and Lord Sundareswarar and the arrival of Lord Kallazhagar in the Vaigai river. The Chennai Sangamam, the Chennai Music Season, and the Mamallapuram Dance Festival are cultural festivals.

Challenges and Future

Modern life has changed how Pongal is celebrated in cities, with gas stoves and apartments replacing courtyard cooking, but people try to keep the traditions. The festival is increasingly celebrated by the Tamil diaspora in Sri Lanka, Singapore, Malaysia, Canada and elsewhere.

Quick Facts

- Pongal is celebrated over four days: Bhogi, Thai Pongal, Mattu Pongal and Kaanum Pongal, starting around 14 January.
- Jallikattu is a traditional bull-taming sport held during Mattu Pongal; the Supreme Court upheld the Tamil Nadu law in 2023.
- Kolam is a decorative design drawn at the doorstep with rice flour to welcome prosperity.
- Pongal thanks the Sun God and cattle for the harvest.
- Tamil New Year (Puthandu) is on 14 April.